

noCommerce + OpenTelemetry

Checkout Flow Observability

Instrumentation Decision



- Chose "Customer places an order" — the most business-critical flow; if checkout fails, the store loses money
- Instrumented at `OrderProcessingService.PlaceOrderAsync` — where payment, persistence, notifications and events are orchestrated in a single method
- ASP.NET auto-instrumentation covers HTTP. `SqlClient` covers SQL. I only needed to instrument what's in between
- Surgical approach: 3 files changed (`OrderProcessingService.cs`, `Program.cs`, `NopTelemetryConstants.cs`), business logic untouched, zero overhead if OTEL SDK is absent

End-to-End Tracing

POST /checkout/0pcConfirmOrder

- checkout.place_order
 - checkout.process_payment
 - checkout.save_order
 - *SQL queries*
 - checkout.send_notifications
 - checkout.publish_event

auto - ASP.NET

custom

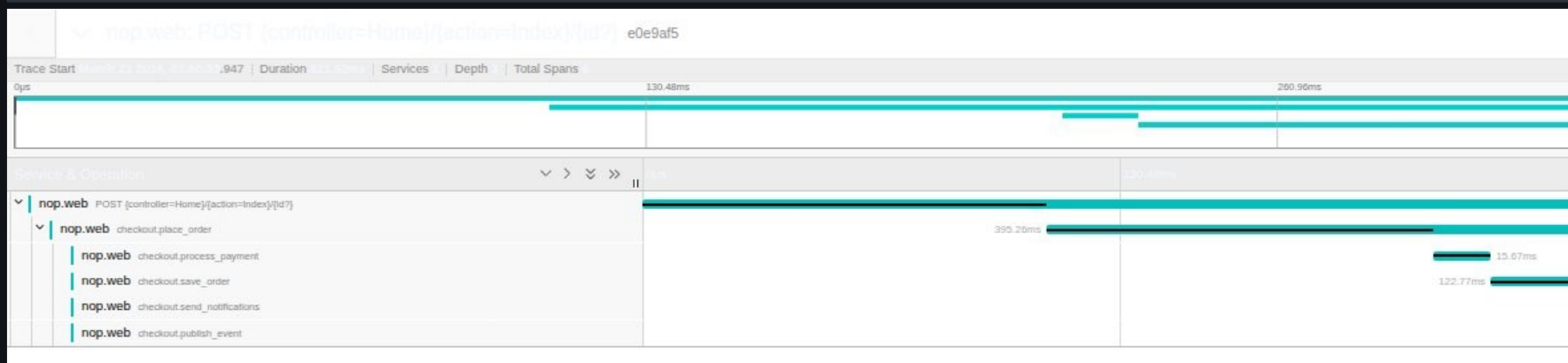
custom

custom

auto - SqlClient

custom

custom



Included: order.total, payment.method, order.items | Excluded: emails, addresses, names, card numbers (zero PII)

3 Custom Metrics — The 2am Test

Metric	Type	If it fires at 2am, the on-call engineer knows...
<code>nop.checkout.place_order.attempts</code>	Counter	Checkout volume dropped or spiked abnormally — checkout may be unreachable
<code>nop.checkout.place_order.failures</code>	Counter	The checkout pipeline is broken — users cannot complete orders
<code>nop.checkout.place_order.duration</code>	Histogram	DB or payment gateway is degraded — p95 rising before visible errors appear

attempts + failures → error rate in Grafana | duration → detects degradation before failures become visible

Privacy — Defence in Depth

In code

- Span attributes are strictly operational: order.total, payment.method, order.items
- No emails, addresses, names or card numbers are ever recorded
- Explicit decision for every attribute — full control at the point of instrumentation

OTel Collector — pii-redact processor

- Deletes before export: authorization headers, cookies, emails, SQL statements, query strings, request bodies
- Why here? Auto-instrumentation (ASP.NET, SqlConnection) can capture PII without my control — the Collector is the last barrier
- Even if something escapes in code, it is filtered here before reaching Jaeger or Prometheus

Rejected alternative: filtering only in code — fragile, auto-instrumentation escapes our control

What I Did NOT Instrument — and Why

Not instrumented	Reasoning
Controllers	ASP.NET auto-instrumentation already covers all HTTP spans
Generic EventPublisher	Would affect the entire system (login, newsletter...) — instrumented only the OrderPlacedEvent
Plugins (Brevo, Avalara)	Independent modules, out of checkout scope
Cache (IStaticCacheManager)	Overhead on thousands of operations per request — noise with no value

Internal checkout methods are protected virtual — subclass override would be possible but fragile and disproportionate. Chose direct surgical change in the service.

Live Demo

Load Test

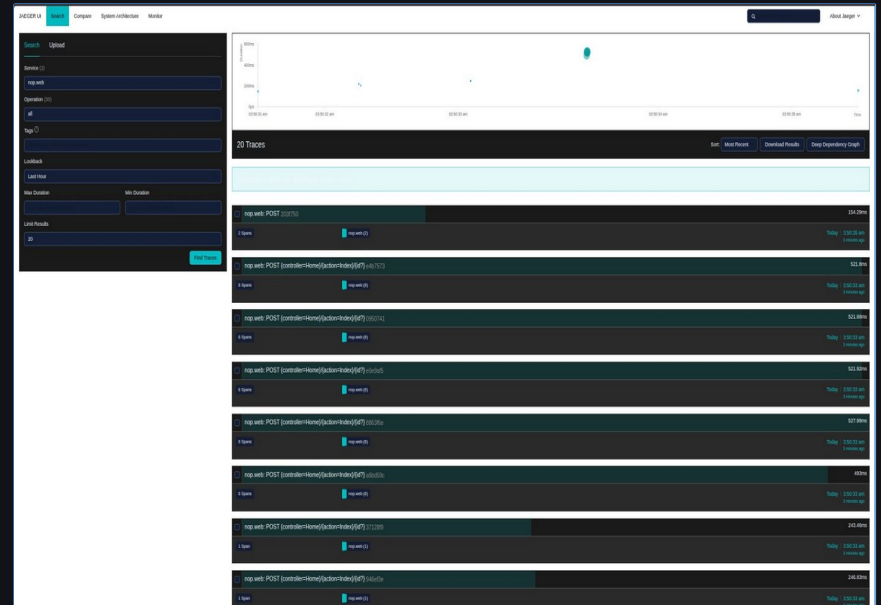
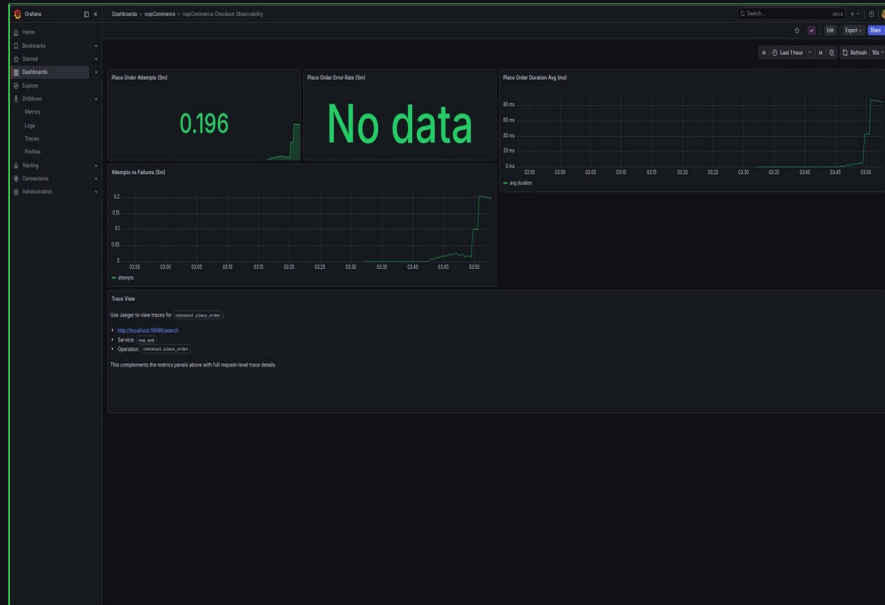
```
k6 run loadtest/checkout-flow.js
```

Grafana

localhost:3000

Jaeger

localhost:16686



Backup screenshots — real demo runs live with k6 generating traffic